

M9: Negative Judgments

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Medically Reviewed by Cimone Safilian-Hanif, PhD in International Psychology, on January 31, 2024

New

Virtual Coach

Work step-by-step through the Mindfulness exercise with the virtual coach.

TRY IT NOW

1. Introduction

We make judgments all the time. You go out to lunch with your family. Your sister is late, monopolizes the conversation, and leaves you with the bill. You make a judgment, "she is really selfish". You took some observations you made (her lateness, her dominating the conversation, and her leaving you to pay the bill) and made a judgment. Or maybe you look out the window, see rain and wind, and make the judgment that the weather is bad.

These negative judgments are often unconscious and unproductive. They often stem from cognitive biases and distorted thinking patterns. These biases can cause us to perceive situations, others, or ourselves in a negative light. Negative judgments often make us feel bad and make us less effective at managing the situation.



Watch on

DBT Mindfulness: Negative Judgments

In this exercise we are going to be more mindful of when we are making negative judgments and how they make us feel.



2. Instructions



The purpose of this [mindfulness exercise](#) is to become more aware of how unwanted negative judgements are becoming part of your automatic thoughts. (In the next exercise, we will practice letting go of these negative judgments).

To begin, print the worksheet provided in Section 3 below.

In this exercise we are going to note down when we have negative judgments over the course of the day.

1. Situation

In this column you will briefly describe the situation that triggered your negative judgment. Write down where you were, and when in the day this happened. For example, maybe you are sitting in your office doing a dull task. Maybe you are out with a friend drinking coffee in the afternoon and she says something unpleasant.

2. Judgment

Write down what you were thinking about. Write down the exact words that crossed your mind. For example, maybe you thought: "I hate my monotonous job, I wish I was working on something more exciting and not stuck in an office.". Or, if you were out with your friend, maybe you were thinking "She never accepts my decisions and she always has to give me advice that I didn't ask for. What a jerk!"

3. Resulting Emotion

Here you should write down how you felt when you were judging the situation. Negative judgments generally result in negative emotions. If left unnoticed, these negative emotions produce more judgments which cause more negative emotions... (it's a vicious cycle). Example: "I feel sad and depressed", or "I feel angry and annoyed".

4. Outcome

in the office situation, maybe you got quiet and you weren't doing your job as well as before. Or, said something snide to your friend and ignored her for a week.

Do this exercise every day for a week. Then move on to the next exercise where we work on letting go of negative judgments.

Below are some examples that will introduce you to the worksheet you will be writing in:



3. Worksheet & Virtual Coach

Print out the worksheet below, and when you find yourself having a negative judgment note down the following four things, as described above:

[DBT Mindfulness:
Negative Judgments Virtual
Coach \(BETA\).](#)

[DBT Mindfulness:
Negative Judgments
Worksheet \(PDF\).](#)



4. FAQs

– What if I can't find enough time during the day to do this exercise?

Although it is best if you tried to do this exercise throughout the whole day so that you won't forget the situations and what exactly happened, if you can't find the time for it, you can do it at the end of the day. During the day try to be mindful of the situations that will trigger your negative judgments so that you will have a better memory of them at the end of the day.

– Do negative judgments always cause negative emotions?

There are some negative judgments that do not necessarily cause emotional pain (like, the weather is cold today). There are neutral and positive judgments as well (for example, my daughter always gets excellent grades at school) which can be the basis for negatively judging a situation that doesn't meet our expectations (my daughter always gets excellent grades at school, so how come she messed up this exam?). In this exercise though, we are just going to focus on the negative judgments, since they are the ones that cause the most unproductive (negative) emotions.

– Should I completely try to avoid judging things?

The point of this exercise is not to completely get rid of judgments, because sometimes judgments are necessary: you consider whether or not a certain situation is good or bad for you, whether it's safe for you or not, you assess your work performance so that you know whether or not you should change something in the way you work.

However, negative judgments are often not useful, because even if there is something that you think should be changed or is negative, there is probably a clearer and more productive way of thinking about it. Saying "This job is really bad for me" doesn't really say a lot or produce a positive

depth and productive understanding of the situation.



5. Disclaimer

If you have any behavioral health questions or concerns, please talk to your healthcare or mental healthcare provider. This article is supported by peer-reviewed research and information drawn from behavioral health societies and governmental agencies. However, it is not a substitute for professional behavioral health advice, diagnosis, or treatment.

Previous Exercise:
[M8 Wise Mind](#)



Next Exercise:
[M10 Letting Go Of Judgments](#)

Comments about Negative Judgments



Abdul Aziz
[June 15, 2020](#)

Thank you very much! I don't know how to thank you for all this free information and exercises.. it's helped me a lot 😊

ADMIN – Hi Abdul,

Great to hear that the lessons and exercises were useful to you! We appreciate your reaching out, it put a big smile on our faces.

[REPLY](#)



Anna Vita
[November 8, 2022](#)

As a mental health counselor DBT focus and trauma based approach, I can't thank you enough for building this amazing resource for us MH therapists and clients. Your work is amazing and easy to understand 😊
Appreciate a lot

[REPLY](#)



Lisa
[April 6, 2023](#)

It just does NOT make sense why this is not taught in grade school. It is more beneficial than anything else they are teaching.

[REPLY](#)



June 17, 2023

I try not to be too judgmental of people as I dont like thinking people may be that way towards me. But some situations really annoy me like crazy drivers and loud vehicles late at night disturbing everyone especially the elderly.

[REPLY](#)



Lawren

August 19, 2024

I just love your teaching style. I am grateful for this class. Thank you!

[REPLY](#)



Veena

August 13, 2025

Thanks. Once you are aware of your negative judgements and make a note of them ,how to handle them and get out of this habit.

[REPLY](#)



Frederick Adiak

November 2, 2025

This exercise is really helpful and help to improve the mental health of individuals. Looking forward to learning more

[REPLY](#)



"Life changer! I struggled with depression and anxiety before I did this course. Do it!"

- Suzanne R.



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